subsequent negotiating position in the NSG, was flawed and proved to be ultimately unsuccessful.

Based on the assessment that there would be opposition both internally as well as in the West on any nuclear deal between India and the United States, a new three-pronged Chinese narrative unfolded after it became apparent that India and the US were seriously exploring a nuclear deal. The first message was for India, namely that China's nuclear posture was oriented towards the United States and, therefore, India had nothing to worry about. The second message was for the United States, namely that India's nuclear programme was oriented towards Pakistan (not China) over the Kashmir issue, and that South Asia was a powder keg prepped to explode into nuclear war. Thus, any latitude given to India in the NSG should be looked at not simply in terms of India's energy needs but in the context of possible nuclear conflict in South Asia. The third message was for the rest of the international community, namely, that they had helped to build the non-proliferation regime brick-by-brick through sacrifices, and any weakening of the multilateral regime would increase the dangers of nuclear conflict for all. Therefore, India's case should be viewed as the thin end of the wedge that could lead to the collapse of the whole structure with consequent danger to the world.

Having divided the strategy into three distinct parts, China proceeded to diplomatically deal with each of them.

Tackling India was complicated. On the one hand, China was distrustful of India. On the other hand, the restoration of ties after the 1998 nuclear tests had brought tangible benefits for China, including in the form of progress on the settlement of the Boundary Question (The Agreement on Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for Settlement of the India–China Boundary Question) and clear iteration by both major political parties, the BJP and the Congress, of Tibet being an integral part